Royal College of Art
Postgraduate Art and Design

Programme Specification

1. General Information

Programme title:	Photography
Award:	Master's
Qualification Framework level:	Level 7
School/Department or equivalent:	School of Arts and Humanities
Campus location(s):	Kensington, Battersea
Total UK credits:	180
Date valid from/to:	2026-27

2. Programme Philosophy

The MA Photography programme at the RCA comprises a unique, cross-disciplinary community of artists and writers working at the cutting edge of contemporary photographic practice and image-making. We understand photography to be an expansive and evolving practice, which includes the still and moving image, publishing, performance, installation, social practice, sound, synthetic media, text, and writing. Central to our approach is the practising, theorising, and receiving of photography as a field unrestricted by the conventions of material, medium, format, discipline, and genre. Important to our programme ethos is a commitment to process; to the unknown, indeterminate, speculative, and hybrid.

We are committed to probing what the photographic image is, and could be, across contemporary art practices. From diverse perspectives we consider digital and analogue forms of photography in relation to socio-political debates, intercultural discourses, exchanges between theory and practice, and emerging modes of circulation and distribution. Driven by research-led teaching and state-of-the-art technical facilities, you will contribute to vital discussions about the future of the image today at an urgent time of ecological crisis and technological change impacted by questions of visibility and representation.

Our faculty of artists, writers, and theorists will support you to develop your work into a critical, reflective, and professionally robust practice. Unique to your experience at the RCA will be the themed *practice group* that you will join at the start of the year. Each practice group is led by a faculty member; emphasising communal learning and encouraging curiosity. The practice group is an invitation to push at the critical, conceptual, practical, and material possibilities of your research and practice in dialogue with others. You will attend to important aesthetic, theoretical, cultural, and historical contexts for your work.

3. Educational Aims and Outcomes of the Programme

<u>Programme aims</u>

- To provide a learning environment which encourages and cultivates experimentation and

self-reflexivity in order to expand the practice and understanding of photography within contemporary art;
- To enable you to plan and produce artworks that are challenging and technically and conceptually innovative;
- To situate photography within the context of contemporary art practices and theories;
- To establish a dialogue in your practice that negotiates received theories;
- To enrich your experience by facilitating interdisciplinarity across the postgraduate culture of the School Arts and Humanities.

Upon successful completion of the programme, you will be expected to meet the requirements of both the College-wide Learning Outcomes and your Programme-Specific Learning Outcomes.

College-Wide Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Interrogate and articulate the intentions of your work in relation to the critical and conceptual context of your field(s) of study;
- Independently plan and produce work that is informed by developments at the forefront of your field(s) of study;
- Evaluate and critique the principles and methods of research in your field(s) of study, and apply these principles to your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice;
- Demonstrate originality in how you translate knowledge into practice;
- Communicate your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice to a non-specialist audience;
- Critically reflect on the likely public impact of your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice, and on your responsibilities as a practitioner;
- Define your professional ambitions and identify the challenges involved in meeting them.

Programme-Specific Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Situate your practice in relation to contemporary cultural discourses and demonstrate how your work is innovative within your chosen field;
- Develop material knowledge through ongoing experimentation in practice, engaging in continual critical reflection through active and responsive evaluation;
- Independently create a body of work that experiments with, and is informed by photographic practices and discourses at the forefront of contemporary art;
- Proficiently communicate the aims and intentions of your practice selecting appropriate strategies for both specialist and non-specialist audiences alike;
- Develop a clear understanding of what it means to be a responsible practitioner, critically engaging with the implications of making your practice public;
- Define your professional ambitions and identify strategies needed to implement them.

4. What Will I Learn?

Curriculum Map

Term 1	Term 2	Term 3
Situating Photography - Practice and Discourse (45 units)	Urgency of the Arts (School-wide Unit, 15 credits)	Independent Research Project (60 credits)
	Making Public (30 credits)	
AcrossRCA (College-wide Unit) (15 credits)	Core Skills (15 Credits)	

Programme Structure

Unit Title	Term	Credit Value	Core or Elective?
Situating Photography - Practice and Discourse.	1	45	Core
AcrossRCA (College-wide unit)	1	15	Core
Making Public	2	30	Core
Core Skills	2	15	Core
Urgency of the Arts (School-wide unit)	2	15	Core
Independent Research Project	3	60	Core

Situating Photography - Practice and Discourse

The first unit orientates students through resource inductions and workshops. They will be introduced to the programme community in student and staff presentations. Students will be divided into groups based upon their area of practice, and within which they will receive tutorials, engage with guest artists, participate in workshops and visit galleries and other relevant sites.

Making Public

This unit situates photography as an expanded and expanding field in contemporary art. Particular attention is placed on the materiality and performativity of the image.

AcrossRCA - College-wide unit (15 credits) Term 1

Taking place in term 1, this unit aims to support you to meet the challenges of a complex, uncertain and changing world by bringing you together with students from across the college to work collaboratively in cross-programme interdisciplinary teams. In your team, you will develop a self-initiated themed project, informed by expertise within and beyond the College. The focus of the unit is on learning through the process of the collaborative development of an idea. Rather than aiming for a completed product, solution or concrete answer, AcrossRCA is about an openness to what is generated through experimentation, dialogue and reflexivity. What happens when we move across disciplinary borders and put the kinds of knowledge, experience and skills we each bring to the RCA into conversation with others?

Core Skills -School-wide unit (15 credits) Term 2

The aim of the Core Skills unit is to support you in advancing your academic and professional skills to help you reflect upon your responsibility as a practitioner and researcher in the world. Consisting

of a School-wide lecture series and in-Programme seminars and workshops, you will consider how your practice responds to questions of inclusion, diversity, equality, critically, sustainably and risk in relation to contemporary contexts of display, encounter and circulation. Taking place in Term 2, the unit will support you towards your IRP and beyond by asking you to reflect on how the ethical values of your work and research translate into methods and modes of display, engagement, presentation and address.

Urgency of the Arts (School-wide Unit)

In term 2, School of Arts and Humanities Masters' students will participate in a School-wide unit called "The Urgency of the Arts." In this unit we ask how arts and humanities research and practice can engage with our current socio-political climate, and how might it shape, be necessary and essential in contemporary cultural debates.

The unit introduces you to a diverse range of perspectives, approaches and methods relevant to contemporary practice and thought in the arts and humanities. The delivery, predominantly based on workshops and featuring specialist presentations by leading artists, aims to assist you in recognizing, questioning, expanding, and reevaluating your own artistic practices and disciplinary assumptions. Through interactions with staff and students from across the School, as well as through a variety of methodological approaches, you will develop an understanding of the contemporary concerns that shape and influence artistic practice. You will be encouraged to reflect on these as a means to articulate the potential of your own work within the context of broad cultural landscapes and urgent cultural debates.

Independent Research Project (IRP)

Part A: **Independent practice**

You will explore ways to make your independent project public, working towards an exhibition of your artwork. You work autonomously towards an understanding of practice-led methodologies, critical reflection and exhibition.

Part B: **Public Exhibition**

You will come together to make an exhibition exploring the practical and conceptual implications of staging, making public, and working in conjunction with others. The making of the exhibition is a reflexive site for innovation and development. A critique takes place within the context of the exhibition when you will present your work to academic staff as well as your peers.

Part C: **Professional Practice**

After the exhibition there will be a programme of professional practice seminars that will be predominantly staffed by arts professionals. These seminars provide a context to explore ideas of reception, dissemination and professional identity.

Towards the end of the unit, using skills gained from the professional practice seminars, you will consolidate the work presented in your exhibition and work towards developing a group presentation for a student symposium. Working in collaboration with your peers, the symposium presentation will demonstrate your ability to establish your professional identity, supporting the further dissemination of your practice beyond the institution.

There are three Independent Study weeks included in your programme (one per term). During these weeks there will be no scheduled teaching or assessment, and limited access to Technical Services. Self-service will be available for inducted users, and you may independently use computing and technology zones, bench spaces, and the resources store and art shop. These weeks are intended for you to work independently, and technical supervision, fabrication support, or supervision of high-risk activities will not be available.

5. How Will I Learn?

Situating Photography

Lexicon

- **Orientation:** Introduction to the culture and philosophy of the programme, programme staff, the locations and facilities.
- **Briefing:** Introductory sessions present the aims, objectives, delivery and assessment procedures of each unit.
- **Induction:** Mandatory inductions to various imaging-related technical areas, including darkrooms (film development and printing), photographic studios, lighting, digital workspaces and workflow.
- **Lecture:** A series of lectures attending to current debates in contemporary photography delivered by visiting speakers, artists, curators and theorists.
- **Seminar:** A series of seminars that explore the discourses of photography.
- **Workshop**: A hands-on/practical learning session, typically led by a visiting artist.
- **Field Trip**: An off-campus visit to a gallery, museum or other relevant site.
- **Individual Tutorial:** One-to-one conversations discussing your practice and progress.
- **Group Tutorial:** Small group meetings led by a Tutor and focused upon a specific topic or theme.
- **Critical Reflection:** A short text accompanied by artwork that reflects on your progress across the unit and includes an evaluation of your practice.

Where field trips/study visits are a core part of the teaching, these are mostly in the London area and you will only pay for travel expenses. Any extra-curricular visits/trips are optional and will be at your own expense.

Making Public

Lexicon

- **Personal Tutorial:** One-to-one conversations discussing your practice and progress towards making your practice public.
- **Group Tutorial:** Small group meetings led by a Tutor and focused upon a specific topic or theme.
- **Sign-up Tutorial:** You select a Programme Tutor, other than your Personal Tutor, for a one-to-one tutorial.
- **Open Studio Crit:** You install and present your work to your peers and a Tutor.
- **Lecture:** A series of lectures attending to current debates in contemporary photography delivered by visiting speakers, artists, curators and theorists.
- **Seminar Programme:** A series of seminars that explore the discourses of photography.
- **Select Workshops**: These might include Bookmaking, Online Publishing, Sustainability in Photography, AI platforms.

Independent Research Project
Lexicon

- **Personal Tutorial:** One-to-one conversations discussing your practice and progress towards making your practice public.
- **Sign-up Tutorial:** You select a Programme Tutor, other than your Personal Tutor, for a one-to-one tutorial.
- **Exhibition Install:** Together with academic and technical staff support.
- **Exhibition Group Crit:** This is led by invited external arts professionals.
- **Professional Practice Seminars:** You will be introduced to skills that will support the reception and dissemination of your work on a number of platforms. These will help to consolidate your practice beyond the institution.

Your studies are divided into three terms and comprise scheduled staff-led time such as lectures, seminars and tutorials, as well as independent learning. Each term consists of 60 credits which equates to 600 study hours. During each week you should, as a full-time student, expect about 40 study hours. This is made up of two components:

- contact hours (approximately 5-10 per week) which involve timetabled interaction with tutors (for example, in seminars, critiques and tutorials), fostering intellectual exchange by way of clarifying concepts, addressing key questions and cultivating critical thinking;
- the time you dedicate to developing your work independently (in addition to the contact hours) by way of self-directed study which can include activities such as making in the workshops, working in the studio, conducting research or preparing for assessment.

The amount of time you spend in self-directed, independent study will normally increase as you progress to the final term, particularly as you focus on the public exhibition or completion of your work. The precise pattern of contact hours will vary by unit, term and mode of study.

6. Assessment and Feedback

Regulations
The programme is subject to the Academic Regulations of the Royal College of Art (*the regulations are subject to annual updates and amendments*).
Unit assessment

Situating Photography

Assessment type: online submission

Assessment pattern: Formative and summative assessment takes place in the form of dialogic assessment tutorials in which you will discuss how your work is meeting the learning outcomes for the unit. You will have a formative assessment tutorial early in the term during which you will present a practice and research plan, which will be agreed between you and your tutor. The plan should set out your goals for the unit outlining the ideas you will explore, your work's connection to your practice group and the practical processes you intend to deploy to explore these ideas. Your summative assessment tutorial at the end of the term will ask you to present your developing body of work (as set out in your practice and research plan) and critically reflect on the success of the work. Your tutor will give you verbal feedback at the assessment tutorial. Following the summative assessment tutorial you will write up assessment feedback discussed during the tutorial, including agreed actions for development of your work in the next unit.

Making Public

Assessment type: online submission and critique

Assessment pattern: A formative assessment takes place in the form of a proposal for the unit's Open Studio Critique. In the middle of the term you will install and exhibit the work outlined in your formative assessment tutorial. On completion of unit submission, you will submit an online Critical Reflection. This can be in the form of a website, podcast, interview, video, personal statement, blog, performance, talk, collaborative event or portfolio. In addition, you will be asked to write a brief outline of your proposal for your IRP.

Independent Research Project

Assessment Type: Exhibition of work, publication and symposium presentation.

Assessment pattern:
The first assessment is of the work completed for public exhibition, which takes as part of the final term. You will present your work to peers and within a group critique. Following the critique, you will write a self-assessment document summarizing the verbal feedback that you received in the critique and reflecting on the work that you made. You will also receive written feedback from academic staff on the work presented in the public exhibition. The second assessment occurs in a group presentation for the student symposium. Prior to the event you will submit documentation of your group's contribution to the symposium, for which you will receive written feedback. The third assessment occurs in the form of an exit tutorial, after which you will submit a reflection on the verbal feedback you receive on your work.

Information regarding individual assessments will be included in the unit descriptors, available at the beginning of the academic year.

7. What Award Can I Get?

To be awarded an RCA MA degree you need to gain 180 credits at level 7 of the Framework for

Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ). This will involve successfully completing all units.

Exit awards: Exit awards: If you have gained at least 60 credits at Level 7, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Certificate. If you have gained at least 120 credits at level 7, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Diploma.